

Professional Services Training: Applying Demand First to Daily Purchasing

A worked example. This is what Training_Module_Builder.md produced when it was run on Cardiff's Sustainable Futures plan. It is kept so Exercise 05 works for anyone who did not do Exercise 04 or who lost their own. Yours will differ, and that is fine.

Who this is for

This session is designed for professional services staff who make, approve, or raise requisitions for departmental purchases. It assumes no prior reading of the university's sustainability plan and focuses entirely on practical application.

Objectives

By the end of this 30-minute session, a participant will:

1. Categorise a proposed departmental purchase into the correct step of the Demand First decision hierarchy when presented with a purchasing request.
2. Draft two demand-reduction alternatives for a standard goods or services request prior to submitting an order.
3. Apply the four-step Demand First process to evaluate and finalise a real-world purchasing decision.

Note on objective wording: terms such as “understand the policy” or “be aware of the ladder” were excluded because internal comprehension cannot be directly observed or measured in a practical workflow.

What the document actually says

The *Sustainable Futures* plan establishes a strict decision-making sequence called the **Demand First** principle to guide all institutional activities, including procurement. The policy explicitly states that reducing demand from the outset is the most effective approach, prioritising choices from most preferred to least preferred:

- **Step 1: Avoid and minimise demand (most preferred).** Question if the resource or service is essential and whether the department can manage without it. If justified, reduce the quantity needed through sharing, improved planning, efficiency measures, or behavioural change.
- **Step 2: Source low-impact alternatives.** If resource use cannot be avoided, select options with the lowest environmental impact. This includes choosing renewable, recycled, or sustainably sourced materials, suppliers with strong environmental credentials, and low-carbon technologies.
- **Step 3: Ensure circularity and recovery.** Ensure products, materials, and infrastructure are specified so they can be repaired, reused, refurbished, or recycled at the end of their useful life.
- **Step 4: Manage unavoidable impacts responsibly (least preferred).** Address remaining residual impacts transparently. Local-only, like-for-like offsetting is permitted strictly as a final measure for unavoidable impacts.

The document notes that procurement implementation will be managed through devolved implementation plans across Professional Services and local units.

Walkthrough

Scenario. A department administrator receives a request to purchase 500 plastic-bound printed delegate workbooks and 500 plastic pens for an upcoming campus conference.

- **Step 1, avoid and minimise demand.** The administrator questions whether physical workbooks are essential. They go fully digital for the conference agenda and materials via a web link, eliminating the workbook order entirely. For note-taking, they review existing departmental storage and find 200 unused wooden pencils from a previous event, reducing the new pen request from 500 to 300.
- **Step 2, source low-impact alternatives.** For the remaining 300 pens, the administrator bypasses standard virgin plastic and sources pens made from 100% recycled cardboard with bio-based ink, from an accredited sustainable supplier.
- **Step 3, ensure circularity and recovery.** The administrator confirms the cardboard pens are fully recyclable at end of life, and sets up a collection box at the event exit to gather unused pens for future campus events.
- **Step 4, manage unavoidable impacts responsibly.** The carbon footprint of shipping the recycled pens is noted as a residual impact. The administrator verifies that the vendor uses local delivery methods to minimise transit emissions.

Practice

Task, 8 minutes. You receive a request on Monday morning to purchase 15 new desktop display monitors for a team office refit. Apply the Demand First ladder to this purchase and write down your action plan for steps 1 to 3.

A strong response contains:

- **Step 1 action.** An explicit check of current departmental assets or campus central storage to see whether existing monitors can be reallocated, or an assessment of whether hybrid working patterns allow desk-sharing, reducing the required number from 15 to a smaller figure.
- **Step 2 action.** Specification of energy-efficient models made from post-consumer recycled plastics, if new purchases remain necessary.
- **Step 3 action.** Confirmation that vendor take-back, repair options, or component recycling plans are included in the purchase agreement.

Check your understanding

Question 1. A team needs additional storage for physical project files. The requisition originator submits an order for three new steel filing cabinets. Which action aligns with step 1 of the Demand First principle?

- A. Purchasing steel cabinets made from 80% recycled content.
- B. Auditing current filing cabinets to clear archived files for shredding or digitisation, freeing up space and avoiding buying new cabinets.
- C. Ordering timber cabinets sourced from local, sustainably managed forests.
- D. Buying the steel cabinets and paying a fee to plant native trees locally to offset the manufacturing carbon.

Correct answer: B. Step 1 requires avoiding and minimising demand at the source, through better resource use or planning, before purchasing anything. A is step 2, sourcing low-impact or recycled alternatives. C is also step 2, sourcing sustainable alternative materials. D is step 4, offsetting and managing residual impacts, which is least preferred and must not replace demand avoidance.

Question 2. When is local carbon offsetting acceptable under the university's sustainability plan?

- A. Whenever a product is required urgently and low-impact alternatives are too expensive.
- B. As a standard first step for all large capital equipment purchases.
- C. Only as a final measure for residual impacts that cannot be eliminated or mitigated after working through the earlier steps.
- D. Whenever purchasing goods from international suppliers.

Correct answer: C. The policy explicitly positions local offsetting as a final measure, strictly for unavoidable residual impacts after direct mitigation has been applied. A is wrong because urgency and cost do not bypass demand reduction or low-impact sourcing. B is wrong because offsetting is step 4, least preferred, and cannot be a first-step solution. D is wrong because international sourcing must first address demand reduction and low-impact alternatives.

Where to go next

- Access local departmental procurement guidance and central asset-sharing registers via your unit's Sustainability Implementation Group.
- Direct operational procurement questions or feedback to the central Sustainability Team at SustainableCU@cardiff.ac.uk.

Timed session breakdown, 30 minutes

- **00:00 to 00:05.** Context and objectives.
- **00:05 to 00:12.** Policy framework, what the document actually says.
- **00:12 to 00:18.** Case example, the walkthrough.
- **00:18 to 00:26.** Individual application, the practice task.
- **00:26 to 00:30.** Knowledge check and wrap-up.

Gap note

Where the source document is silent, or relies on processes it does not define:

- **Financial spend thresholds: NONE STATED.** The document does not specify monetary limits at which the Demand First process becomes mandatory rather than optional.
- **Approval sign-offs: NONE NAMED.** The document devolves operational plans to Professional Services and local units, but names no role responsible for signing off Demand First compliance on day-to-day requisitions.
- **Approved supplier list: NONE STATED.** Specific low-impact vendors, asset-sharing portals and certified sustainability registers are not listed in the strategy text.
- **Quantified demand-reduction targets: NONE STATED.** Overall Scope 1, 2 and 3 ambitions are noted, but percentage reduction targets for general procurement are left to the annual Environmental Sustainability Action Plans.
- **House conventions applied.** The 30-minute timing structure, the conference, monitor and filing-cabinet scenarios, and the choice of objectives are instructional design additions. They are not quoted from the source text.

These are the questions worth putting to whoever owns the plan.